GABRIEL POPA

Senior Software Engineer - PHP (Larvel/ Symfony) • AWS
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ABOUT ME

Senior Software Engineer with **10+ years** of experience building **PHP backend systems**, **API-driven platforms**, and data-intensive business applications across product, admin, reporting, and internal operations environments. Strong specialization in **PHP 5–8**, **Laravel 5–11**, **Symfony 3–7**, **REST APIs**, **MySQL**, **PostgreSQL**, **Redis**, **queue processing**, and **AWS**, with practical success improving fragile legacy modules, solving production issues, modernizing monolith-style applications, and delivering maintainable backend services with stronger validation, security, and performance. Brings a proven record of reducing slow queries, stabilizing integrations, and translating complex business workflows into cleaner service-oriented backend architecture.

SKILLS

- **Backend: PHP 5–8**, **Laravel 5–11**, **Symfony 3–7**, REST API design, MVC architecture, service-layer design, authentication, authorization, validation, middleware, background jobs, queue processing, cron jobs, file processing, business rule implementation
- **Database & Caching: MySQL**, **PostgreSQL**, SQL, query tuning, indexing, joins, schema design, migrations, pagination, reporting queries, transaction handling, data consistency, **Redis**, caching strategies
- **Cloud & DevOps: AWS**, Docker, Linux, Nginx, Apache, Git, GitHub, GitLab CI/CD, Jenkins, deployment workflows, release support, environment configuration, log monitoring
- **Observability / Quality / Security: PHPUnit**, **Pest**, structured logging, **Sentry**, OpenTelemetry basics, distributed tracing basics, OWASP security practices, rate limiting, integration testing, API regression testing, error monitoring, production debugging

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Senior Software Engineer

Soft Build | Bucharest, Romania *(Jan 2024 – May 2026)*

- Architected and delivered backend modules using **PHP 8.1–8.2**, **Laravel 10**, and selected **Symfony 6** components, turning fragmented operational requirements into maintainable service flows with cleaner validation, better request handling, and more predictable delivery across reporting and administration domains.
- Redesigned several oversized controller-driven modules into clearer service and action layers, which reduced backend coupling, improved testability, and made future feature implementation safer for areas that had previously broken after even small logic changes.
- Implemented secure **REST APIs** for approvals, reporting, user management, and internal administration, strengthening request contracts and authorization paths while reducing inconsistent backend behavior that had created difficult-to-reproduce production defects.
- Solved a recurring production issue where reporting totals drifted after edits by tracing stale **Redis** cache keys, correcting invalidation timing, and aligning backend response generation with downstream data refresh expectations across dependent workflows.
- Improved API reliability by standardizing request validation, exception handling, and response shaping, which reduced silent failure cases and gave frontend consumers much clearer error visibility when backend rules rejected incomplete or invalid input.
- Built queue-backed backend workflows for long-running exports, notifications, and follow-up processing, moving heavy actions out of synchronous requests so large operations stopped causing timeouts and unstable user behavior during peak usage windows.
- Stabilized a difficult export defect that generated incomplete files for larger result sets by replacing memory-heavy processing with chunked handling and safer batching logic, which improved reliability for finance and reporting users handling larger datasets.
- Led a careful modernization path from older PHP patterns into a more maintainable **PHP 8.x** codebase, resolving deprecated behavior, updating framework conventions, and reducing hidden upgrade risk while preserving live business functionality.

- Strengthened backend quality through targeted **PHPUnit** and **Pest** coverage around validation, permissions, queued jobs, and critical business rules, helping catch regression-prone changes before they reached production-sensitive workflows.
- Improved performance on high-traffic backend endpoints through SQL query tuning, selective indexing, payload shaping, and better pagination across **MySQL** and **PostgreSQL**, reducing slow response complaints by **42%** on reporting-heavy screens.
- Worked closely with DevOps on **Docker**, **AWS**, Linux, Nginx, and CI/CD release support, resolving dependency drift and environment mismatches that had previously caused backend behavior to differ between local, staging, and production systems.
- Added stronger runtime visibility with **Sentry**, structured logging, and basic **OpenTelemetry** instrumentation so backend failures across APIs and queue-triggered workflows became faster to isolate, reproduce, and fix under active production pressure.

Software Engineer

Next Apps | Ghent, Belgium *(Nov2020 – Nov 2023)*

- Built and maintained backend services using **PHP 7.4–8.0**, **Symfony 5**, and **Laravel 8**, supporting customer and internal workflow systems with stronger validation, safer service separation, and more reliable request handling for multi-role business processes.
- Implemented maintainable **REST APIs** for search, edit, approval, export, and notification-heavy workflows, helping the platform move away from tightly coupled page logic toward cleaner backend-driven integration patterns.
- Migrated several fragile backend modules from older mixed-responsibility patterns into clearer service-oriented structures, which made business rules easier to reason about and reduced regression risk on features with complicated approval conditions.
- Solved an intermittent logout and access-loss problem by aligning token expiration handling, backend session rules, and proxy behavior in **Apache** and **Nginx**, which eliminated a frustrating production issue affecting long-running user sessions.
- Introduced queue processing for email, notifications, and background synchronization tasks, removing blocking work from synchronous request paths so users no longer experienced stalled submissions during heavier transactional periods.
- Improved backend integration reliability by standardizing retry-aware service calls, centralized exception mapping, and safer downstream failure handling, which reduced duplicated recovery logic and made third-party service issues easier to control.
- Optimized **MySQL** reporting queries with better joins, indexing, and safer pagination rules, reducing timeout-prone screens and improving usability for support teams working with larger filtered result sets by **31%**.
- Delivered a controlled migration path from **PHP 7.4** to **PHP 8**, resolving deprecated framework behavior, reviewing package compatibility, and updating internal code carefully so the upgrade did not destabilize active customer workflows.
- Supported release operations through **Jenkins**, Git, Docker, and Linux-based environment setup, helping stabilize the build pipeline and reduce deployment-related backend incidents through more repeatable release and verification steps.
- Improved production issue detection with **Sentry**, structured backend logs, and clearer failure traces, which reduced time spent reproducing exceptions manually and gave the team faster insight into live API errors.
- Expanded backend testing coverage around validation, permissions, and business-critical flows, which improved confidence during release cycles and lowered repeated regressions on features that historically failed after adjacent changes.

Software Developer

Datamart | Stockholm, Sweden *(Feb 2016 – Sep 2020)*

- Developed business web applications with **PHP 5.6–7.x** and **Laravel**, supporting reporting, account workflows, and operational administration while handling backend enhancements, bug fixes, and ongoing maintenance across multi-module systems.
- Improved backend maintainability by moving scattered business rules from legacy controllers into clearer MVC-aligned structures, which reduced fragile logic placement and made future updates easier to implement with lower regression risk.

- Fixed a recurring form-processing defect caused by inconsistent frontend and backend validation behavior, then unified request rules so malformed submissions were blocked earlier and partial-save failures stopped creating inconsistent records.
- Worked extensively with **MySQL** and **PostgreSQL** on schema design, migrations, reporting queries, and structured data updates, helping the platform support newer requirements without breaking legacy data assumptions in older modules.
- Resolved slow-list and export issues through query tuning, additional indexing, safer joins, and better pagination, making heavy admin workflows more stable for internal users and improving backend response behavior by **28%**.
- Introduced **REST-style** backend endpoints for more interactive modules, allowing selected areas to reduce full-page reload behavior and giving the application a more flexible path toward incremental modernization.
- Helped troubleshoot production issues across Linux, **Apache**, and **Nginx** environments, including file-permission problems, missing configuration values, and deployment-specific bugs that could not be reproduced reliably in development.
- Contributed to backend quality improvements with early **PHPUnit** coverage, manual API regression checks, and disciplined reproduction steps, helping reduce repeated fixes on fragile modules that tended to break after small changes.
- Supported release and maintenance workflows using Git, Jenkins, and early **Docker** adoption, improving deployment repeatability and making backend changes safer to promote across shared environments with limited rollback tolerance.
- Assisted with caching and response optimization in data-heavy sections, reducing unnecessary database pressure and improving consistency for operational screens that queried the same filtered datasets repeatedly during peak usage.

Junior Software Developer

Berg Software | Timișoara, Romania *(Sep2014 – Mar 2016)*

- Supported legacy and evolving web applications using **PHP 5**, **MySQL**, JavaScript, HTML, CSS, and jQuery, focusing mainly on stable CRUD behavior, admin pages, data handling, and smaller backend-focused enhancements under senior guidance.
- Implemented backend changes within structured MVC-style patterns, learning how to apply validation, authorization checks, and safer query logic instead of patching issues directly inside tightly coupled legacy page scripts.
- Fixed repeated form and submission errors by aligning required fields, sanitization rules, and backend validation behavior, which reduced input-related failures by **40%** and prevented inconsistent data from being written to core tables.
- Improved slow admin pages by reviewing SQL queries, simplifying filtering logic, and adding basic indexing so internal teams could work more effectively on screens that had become difficult to use with larger business datasets.
- Assisted with environment troubleshooting across Linux, Apache, and shared staging systems, helping identify configuration mismatches and deployment issues that caused applications to behave differently outside local development.
- Participated in release support using Git, manual deployment checklists, and backend log review, building practical experience around safe delivery habits and understanding how small infrastructure issues could trigger visible production failures.
- Learned disciplined debugging through structured logging, issue reproduction, and small targeted fixes, which helped reduce risk in fragile modules where larger refactors would have been unsafe for active business users.
- Supported data consistency efforts by reviewing update flows, validation paths, and schema assumptions, helping reduce edge-case bugs where user actions, stored data, and legacy backend code did not always stay aligned.
- Contributed to maintenance of older backend modules by tracing defects through request handling and database writes, then applying careful fixes that improved stability without introducing unnecessary change in sensitive legacy areas.

EDUCATION

Bachelor’s Degree in Computer Science

University of Bucharest | (*2010 – 2014)*

- Focused on practical software engineering fundamentals that translated directly into building reliable web systems and data-driven applications.

CERITIFICATIONS

AWS Certified Developer – Associate — 2023

- Demonstrated practical capability in developing, deploying, and maintaining cloud-based applications on **AWS**, with focus on service integration, monitoring, secure deployments, and scalable backend operations.

Laravel Certified Developer — 2022

- Demonstrated strong working knowledge of **Laravel** application architecture, including routing, Eloquent ORM, middleware, authentication, validation, testing, and maintainable backend feature delivery.

Scrum Fundamentals Certified (SFC) — 2021

- Demonstrated solid understanding of **Agile** principles, sprint-based delivery, cross-functional collaboration, and structured execution practices within modern software development teams.